INTERVIEW PREP Â· CUT SHEET

The Reusable Story

Five or six experiences are enough, if you can tell each one three or four ways. The ending stays put, word for word, every time you tell it. What changes is *which part you slow down on*, and that depends on what the job needs and what the interviewer is trying to learn about you. Told one way, a bad week in the shop shows you can handle conflict. Told another way, that same week shows you can do more with less.

AIM AT A JOB

Before you pick an experience, pick a job posting. Prep without a target and you're shooting into the air. If you haven't settled on a direction yet, find a posting for work you're considering and practice against it. It doesn't have to be the one you end up applying for, but it has to be a real posting.

Read it and pick out **the two or three things it asks for most**, in its own words. If it keeps saying "takes ownership" and "comfortable with ambiguity," those are your two. Then find the angle that matches each one. An angle is the trait you're trying to prove, and all ten are further down. Those are the angles you build first. The rest can wait.

If you change your mind about the work, swap in a new posting. Your experiences stay the same, and so do the endings. What changes is which angles you lead with.

> **Write this down.** The two or three things this job asks for most, and the angle each one matches.

PICK THE EXPERIENCE

Not the biggest thing you ever did. The thing where **what you decided changed what happened.** If it would have come out the same with anybody else standing there, that's a duty description. Set it aside and pick another one.

The good ones are busy. A lot was going on, you were making calls the whole way through, and you probably didn't think much of it at the time, which is usually the tell. One week like that can carry three or four angles.

BUILDING IT BACKWARD Â· FOUR STEPS

01 Land the result first R

Write the ending before anything else, then *leave it alone*. It stays the same in every version of this story you'll ever tell. Put a number in it if you have one, and if you don't, name what changed instead. Something was broken and then it wasn't, or something didn't exist and then it did.

> **Write this down.** "By the end, _____ ."

02 Ask what would have happened without you `S` `T`

Whatever the answer is, that's your Situation. It's the stakes, and the stakes are the only reason anybody leans in. The rest of the setting is background, and background is where most of us end up burying the good part.

Then say what made it yours to handle. That's your Task. The word makes it sound like somebody assigned it to you, and sometimes somebody did. It can just as easily be a call you had to make, a problem you saw coming and took on before anybody asked, an emergency you had to act on, or an obstacle standing between your people and the mission.

> **Write this down.** "If nobody had stepped in, _____ ." Then, "It was on me to _____ ."

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03 List every decision you made

Write them out one line each. Every disagreement you settled, every trade-off you made, everything you caught before anybody else did, every person you talked around. Most people find eight or nine in a single week, and you want all of them, because **the lines on that list are what every angle gets built from.** Keep it somewhere you can find it, because you'll need it again for the ten angles.

Then go back through and write down **what you were up against on each one.** A person, a deadline, a budget, a rule somebody wrote in 1997, your own bad call from the week before. That's your conflict, and there is no story without conflict. It's the oldest rule in storytelling and it's the one we break most often, because in uniform we were taught to report the outcome and leave ourselves out of it.

If a line on your list had nothing pushing back on it, it wasn't a decision. It was routine, and nobody leans in to hear about routine.

> **Write this down.** Every time you had to choose, and what was pushing back when you chose it.

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04 Point the Action at the angle A

Pick the one or two decisions that answer the angle and give those the detail. Everything else shrinks to a few words or drops out entirely, because the whole answer has to fit in about ninety seconds (more on why further down). You're not making anything up and you're not contradicting yourself anywhere. The rest of it still happened, it's just not what this answer is about.

On a few angles the proof comes at the very end: who could run it without you, what it cost you, how you fixed what you got wrong. Make that your last move, right before the ending, and leave the ending alone.

> **Write this down.** What you did about those decisions, in order, each starting with **I**. Three moves is usually plenty.

ONE EXPERIENCE, THREE ANSWERS

All three of these come out of the same six weeks in the same shop. **The last sentence is identical every time.** What changes is which decision Marcus slows down on.

WHAT HAPPENED

Six weeks out from a change-of-command inspection, the maintenance tracking database locked read-only. Marcus built manual tracking in a spreadsheet, trained six techs, and the shop cleared inspection clean.

- Two weeks earlier he'd noticed writes slowing to three or four seconds, the same signature that preceded a lockup on the supply system the year before. He flagged it. The ticket sat.
- Because he'd flagged it, he had a rough tracker half-built when the database died.
- No extra manpower, no overtime authority. Manual tracking would cost about 90 minutes a day for six weeks.
- The shop's senior tech, nineteen years in, told him flatly it wouldn't survive an inspection.
- He killed a daily 0700 status report nobody read and moved those hours onto tracking.
- Six techs were trained and running it inside two weeks.

> "Tell me about a time you disagreed with a coworker."

Conflict Resolution

THE OBJECTION

Our tracking system went down six weeks before a major inspection, and I put together a manual workaround. The problem was that the person I needed most was against it. Our senior tech had nineteen years in that shop, and he told me flatly that a spreadsheet wasn't going to survive an inspection. My first instinct was to go around him. I had the authority to. I didn't. I asked him what specifically he thought would break. About ten minutes in, it came out that it wasn't really about the spreadsheet. He was going to have to learn a new tool in front of six people who'd been calling him the expert for a decade. So I asked him to run the first training session, and I had him check my column logic beforehand. He caught two errors I would have carried straight into the inspection.

> THE ENDING, UNCHANGED
>
> We went into the inspection with zero discrepancies, and that tracking method was still the shop standard eighteen months later, when I left.

WHY IT LANDS *He gives the other guy's position straight, then finds the objection underneath the one that got said out loud. Nowhere in this does he win an argument.*

> "Tell me about a time you had to do more with less."

Resource Allocation

MORE WITH LESS

Our tracking system went down six weeks before a major inspection, and the manual workaround I built was going to cost real time we didn't have. About ninety minutes a day, every day, for six weeks. Call it sixty man-hours, with no additional people and no overtime authority. So I went looking for those hours. We produced a 0700 status report every morning that took one tech about ninety minutes to build. I spent two days finding out who actually read it. Nobody did. It had been requested by a commander who'd rotated out fourteen months earlier. I killed the report and moved that tech onto tracking. The work got absorbed inside the duty day. Nobody stayed late, and I didn't ask anyone to carry it on top of a full load.

> THE ENDING, UNCHANGED
>
> We went into the inspection with zero discrepancies, and that tracking method was still the shop standard eighteen months later, when I left.

WHY IT LANDS *Anybody can say they did more with less. Sixty hours found inside a report nobody read is the proof, and it's the kind a hiring manager can picture happening at their own company next quarter.*

> "Tell me about a time you took initiative."

Initiative

PATTERN RECOGNITION

Two weeks before our tracking system failed, I'd seen it coming. Writes were taking three or four seconds instead of being instant, and that same slow-write signature had preceded a total lockup on our supply system the year before. I flagged it. The ticket sat, nobody escalated it, and I didn't have the standing to push it any harder. So instead of waiting to be proven right, I started building a manual tracker on my own time. It was about half finished the morning the database went read-only, six weeks out from a major inspection. The shop lost roughly four hours that day instead of the week it would have taken to start from nothing.

> **THE ENDING, UNCHANGED**
>
> We went into the inspection with zero discrepancies, and that tracking method was still the shop standard eighteen months later, when I left.

WHY IT LANDS *The initiative here is the noticing. He saw the pattern first, and the building was just what he did about it. That plays better than "I'm a self-starter," which anybody can say about themselves and nobody can check.*

WHAT NEVER MOVED

The facts. The timeline. The result, word for word. All three versions are true and none of them contradicts the others.

WHAT MOVED

Which decision got the detail. The senior tech carries the whole first version and never comes up in the other two. The 0700 report carries the second and never comes up in the first or third.

TEN ANGLES Â· WHAT EACH ONE NEEDS

An angle is the trait you're trying to prove. Each of the ten below is something an interviewer might be digging for, and they're all laid out the same way.

Take one experience and work through them. For each one, check whether your story actually has what that angle needs. Most decent experiences carry **three or four**. Start with the angles your job posting asks for, then write a version for every other angle that fits. Keep them all and file them under the angle name. Six experiences handled that way is twenty-some answers, and every one of them true.

EACH ANGLE BELOW HAS THESE FOUR PARTS

SPOTLIGHT	What your story needs to have for this angle to work. Check the decisions you listed in step 3. If none of them match, this isn't the angle for this story.
BUILD	How to tell it. What to describe in detail, what to mention quickly, and what to leave out.
WHAT THEY'RE AFTER	What the interviewer is actually trying to find out about you, which is usually not what they literally asked. Before you write anything, say in one sentence how your story shows this. When you're done, read it back and ask whether somebody hearing it would come away believing that about you. If they wouldn't, you told the wrong part.
SOUNDS LIKE	Two ways of saying the same thing in an interview. The weak one states the conclusion and asks them to take your word for it. The strong one hands them the evidence and lets them get there themselves. That's show don't tell, one sentence at a time. The note underneath says why the weak one falls flat.

The four bars are Situation, Task, Action, Result. Compare them to each other, not to the clock. The tallest is where most of your time goes, and a bar at half that height gets about half as much.

ANGLE

Conflict Resolution

THE OBJECTION



SPOTLIGHT

The disagreement itself, and **what the other person actually needed** underneath what they said.

BUILD

State their position fairly. A strawman kills this one instantly. Show the moment you stopped arguing and started asking.

WHAT THEY'RE AFTER

Whether you can hear what somebody is actually saying underneath what they said, and whether disagreement makes you curious or defensive.

SOUNDS LIKE

× "He was just resistant to change."

✓ "He'd sat through two rollouts that got dumped on the shop and then blamed on us when they failed. His objection was never really about the tool."

A strawman is a version of somebody's argument that you've rebuilt so it's easy to knock down. Here's the test. If your description of their position makes them sound stupid, petty, or lazy, you built one, and the interviewer is going to assume you never understood them in the first place. At which point you didn't resolve anything. You just outranked them.

ANGLE

Resource Allocation

MORE WITH LESS



SPOTLIGHT

The arithmetic of it. **What you took from where**, and what you decided was worth less than the thing you funded.

BUILD

Say the numbers out loud. Hours, bodies, dollars, days. Name the thing you cut. A trade-off with no cost isn't a trade-off.

WHAT THEY'RE AFTER

Whether you can make a call under constraint and live with what it cost, instead of asking for more and waiting.

SOUNDS LIKE

× "We were short-handed, so I had to prioritize."

✓ "I had four techs for a six-tech workload. I stopped preventive checks on the two vehicles that barely moved and put those eight hours a week onto the fleet that was actually running."

> Everybody prioritizes. The word carries no evidence with it. What carries evidence is the thing you stopped doing, plus being able to say why that was the right thing to lose. If nothing got given up, no allocating happened.

ANGLE

Initiative

PATTERN RECOGNITION



SPOTLIGHT

What you **noticed before anyone asked you to look**, and what in your experience made it recognizable.

BUILD

Open on the signal, not the action. The part that matters is that nobody tasked you. Say when you asked permission and when you didn't.

WHAT THEY'RE AFTER

Whether you'll spot the problem before it gets assigned to you, and whether your judgment about when to move without permission is any good.

SOUNDS LIKE

× "I'm a self-starter, so I took it on myself to fix it."

✓ "The same three trucks were failing the same inspection point every quarter. Nobody had connected them because each one was logged by a different shift."

> "Self-starter" describes your personality and nobody can check it. The noticing is what they can check. Say what you saw, then say what in your experience let you see it when everybody else walked right past. That second half is the part that makes you worth hiring instead of just busy.

ANGLE

Leadership

THROUGH OTHERS

SPOTLIGHT	The point where **the team could run it without you**, and who was different afterward.
BUILD	Spend the Action on changing someone's mind, workload, or confidence. Name them by role. Say "my night-shift tech," not "personnel."
WHAT THEY'RE AFTER	*Whether you can get something done through other people, instead of doing it all yourself and calling that leadership.*



SOUNDS LIKE

× "I led a team of twelve and we accomplished every mission on time."

✓ "By month three, my two most junior techs were running the shift handoff brief themselves. I sat in the back and didn't say anything."

> Twelve people reporting to you says somebody put them there. That's an org chart. What proves leadership is one specific person doing something they couldn't do before you, and the best version of that story is the one where you end up unnecessary.

ANGLE

Ownership

ACCOUNTABILITY



SPOTLIGHT

The moment you **said a problem was yours**, especially one you helped cause.

BUILD

Spend most of your time on what you took on and why. Say the cost out loud and don't soften it. If you contributed to the mess, say that too; it's the most credible thing you can do.

WHAT THEY'RE AFTER

Whether you'll bring them bad news early, and whether you'll say "that one was mine" when saying it costs you something.

SOUNDS LIKE

× "Mistakes were made early on, but we recovered and got it done."

✓ "I signed off on the parts count without spot-checking it. We came up nine units short on inspection day. That one was mine."

> "Mistakes were made" is a sentence built so that no human being did anything. Interviewers hear it immediately and read it as somebody covering for themselves. Put your name in the sentence, take the two seconds of discomfort, and spend the rest of your time on the fix. That trade buys you more credibility than a clean story ever would.

ANGLE

Adaptability

THE PIVOT



SPOTLIGHT — The day **the old plan died**, and what you did before anybody handed you a new one.

BUILD — Spend your time on the setup, but only the part that *changed*. Give them the before and the break; skip the org chart. Then one clean pivot.

WHAT THEY'RE AFTER — *What you do in the gap after the plan dies and before anybody hands you a new one.*

SOUNDS LIKE

× "I'm flexible and I adapt well to changing situations."

✓ "We'd built the entire six-week schedule around having that bay to ourselves. We lost it on a Tuesday. By Thursday we were running two shifts out of a shared bay at half capacity."

> Adaptability only shows up in a before and an after. If you can't name the plan that died, and what it assumed, there's nothing to adapt from, and "I'm flexible" is just a word sitting on a resume. Give them the old plan in one sentence so the pivot has something to push off of.

ANGLE

Problem-Solving

ANALYTICAL RIGOR



SPOTLIGHT

How you found the **real cause**, including one thing you tested that turned out not to be it.

BUILD

Give two things equal time. First how you defined the actual problem, then how you ruled things out. Show your reasoning, not just your conclusion.

WHAT THEY'RE AFTER

Whether you have a method or you got lucky, and whether you can still think when the answer isn't obvious.

SOUNDS LIKE

× "I troubleshot the issue and resolved it."

✓ "I assumed it was the sensor, because it's always the sensor. I swapped it and the fault came back in nine minutes. That's when I started pulling on the harness instead."

> Put the wrong turn in. This feels backwards, I know. You want to sound competent, so you tell the version where your first guess was right, and that version sounds lucky. The version where you were wrong, caught it, and changed direction sounds like a *method*. The method is what they're hiring.

ANGLE

Collaboration

INFLUENCE WITHOUT AUTHORITY



SPOTLIGHT	The person or section **you had no power over** and needed anyway.
BUILD	Nearly all of this is the Action, and the Action is a conversation. Show what was in it for them. This is the one angle where "we" is correct.
WHAT THEY'RE AFTER	*Whether you can get things done across a line where nobody owes you anything and you can't make them.*

SOUNDS LIKE

× "I worked closely with the supply section to get what we needed."

✓ "Supply wasn't slow-rolling us. They were measured on closed tickets, and ours kept getting reopened. Once I bundled our requests into one monthly order, their numbers went up and our parts showed up."

> "Worked closely with" fills the space where the answer goes. Influence without authority means you figured out what the other side was being measured on and made your ask serve it. Show that and you've demonstrated something plenty of senior people still can't do.

ANGLE

Resilience

SUSTAINED EFFORT



SPOTLIGHT

The stretch where **nothing was working and you kept going**, and what it cost you.

BUILD

Build the setup around how long it went on, not how bad it got. The Action isn't one heroic move; it's the same move repeated. Give the timeline in weeks.

WHAT THEY'RE AFTER

What you're like in month nine, when it isn't interesting anymore and nobody's watching.

SOUNDS LIKE

× "It was an extremely stressful period but I pushed through it."

✓ "Eleven months. Same failure, same paperwork, same Monday call with the same vendor rep. I kept the log anyway, because eventually somebody was going to ask for it. In month eleven somebody did."

> Most of us reach for the worst day and try to make the interviewer feel how bad it was. That isn't what reads. What reads is the calendar and the repetition, the unglamorous fact that you did the same unrewarding thing ninety times and it never once got easier. Give them the number of months.

ANGLE

Learning Agility

YOUR STRONGEST ANGLE



SPOTLIGHT

The gap between **what you knew and what it took**, with the start date and the delivery date said out loud.

BUILD

Spend your time on *method*. Where you went, who you asked, what you broke first on a copy. This answers "you've never held this job before."

WHAT THEY'RE AFTER

Whether they can hand you something you've never done before and then stop worrying about it.

SOUNDS LIKE

× "I'm a quick learner and I picked it up fast."

✓ "I'd never written a line of PowerShell. I took a script I found, broke it deliberately on a test box until I understood which part did what, and had our onboarding checklist automated in three weeks."

> "Quick learner" might be the most common unsupported claim in any interview. Everybody says it, so it lands as nothing. The method is what proves it. Where you started from zero, what you actually did, how long it took. This is the angle that answers the question nobody asks out loud in a career change interview. *Can this person do a job they've never done before?*

FIVE WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

× You tell the one version you rehearsed, no matter what they asked.	→ One angle answers one question. **Re-aim the middle and leave the ending where it is.**
× You change the result to fit the question.	→ Now it's two stories and one of them sounds rehearsed. **The ending is the fixed point.**
× You give every detail because every detail is true.	→ Every detail you don't need **waters down the one that mattered.** True isn't the bar here.

× You say "we" for the part you did alone.	→ "We" in the Situation. **"I" in the Action.** You aren't stealing credit, you're answering the question they asked.
× You shrink it. "It wasn't a big deal, it's just what we did."	→ Standard for *you* is not standard for them. **Report it, don't rate it.**

READ THIS BEFORE YOU ARGUE WITH IT

About the Ninety Seconds

Nobody is scoring you against a stopwatch, and there's no hiring manager alive who stops listening at second ninety-one. **The limit is there to force a decision, and it exists because of one specific habit you're going to have to unlearn.**

You were trained to give complete accounts. An AAR that leaves out a step is a bad AAR. A debrief that skips the sequence is incomplete. A brief that drops the supporting detail comes right back to you. That instinct is *correct in uniform*, and it costs you in an interview, where the person across the table has no context, no stake in the sequence, and maybe two minutes of real attention per question.

> **Cut until it fits. Whatever survives is the part that mattered.**

That's the whole trick. A hard limit is the only thing that reliably makes you *choose*, and the choosing is the skill. It's the same one they're quietly grading when they ask a behavioral question in the first place. Without the limit you'll put in everything that's true, because all of it is true. With it, you find out which forty seconds were carrying the story the whole time.

So if you land at a hundred seconds and every sentence is load-bearing, you're fine, and I'm not dogmatic about the number. If you're at three minutes, though, you aren't being thorough. **You've handed the interviewer the sorting job that was yours to do.** And they won't tell you. They'll just stop asking follow-ups.

BEFORE YOU SAY IT OUT LOUD

1. Can you say the **result in one breath**, with a number or a change in it?
2. Is that sentence **identical** to the one in your other versions of this story?
3. Does your Situation answer "**what if nobody had stepped in**", or does it give them the org chart?
4. Take the label off. Is the angle still obvious from **the Action alone**?
5. Did you translate the jargon **without shrinking it**? "I did logistics" tells them nothing. What moved, how much, how far, on whose deadline.
6. Say it out loud on a timer. **Time it, don't guess at it.**
7. Now tell the same story for a **second angle.** If you can't, either less was going on than you remembered, or you quit your list of decisions too early.

Your first few will come out clunky, and that's just what early reps sound like. The reps fix it.

GOING FURTHER Â· THREE TOOLS FROM STORYWORTHY

Everything up to here is about building the answer. This last part is about telling it, and it's optional. If you're still fighting to get a clean ninety seconds out of one experience, skip this and come back after a few more reps.

All three come from Matthew Dicks, who wrote a book called *Storyworthy* and has won more Moth storytelling competitions than just about anybody. He's teaching people to hold a room from a stage. You're sitting across a table from somebody deciding whether to hire you, which is a quieter job, so take the technique and leave the performance behind. Used well, none of this is visible. Used too early, you sound like somebody who just took a storytelling class, and an interviewer can smell that from the other side of the table, even if they couldn't tell you exactly what tipped them off.

The five-second moment

Dicks argues that every story worth telling is really about one moment, and that the moment takes about five seconds. Something shifts. You understand something you didn't understand five seconds earlier, or you decide something you hadn't decided. Everything else in the story exists to set that moment up and to show what it cost.

By now your Action has one or two decisions in it. Only one of them is the actual story. Find it, give it the detail, and let the other shrink to a clause.

It also tells you what to cut, which is the hard part when you only have ninety seconds. You stop trying to fit the whole week in and start building toward one moment.

WHERE IT GOES **Inside the Action.** This one doesn't add a sentence. It decides which sentence you already have is the one you slow down on.

> WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE
>
> "I asked him what specifically he thought would break. About ten minutes in, it came out that it wasn't really about the spreadsheet. He was going to have to learn a new tool in front of six people who'd been calling him the expert for a decade. So I asked him to run the first training session, and had him check my column logic beforehand."
>
> The highlighted part is the moment. **The sentence before it is setup.** It exists so the moment has somewhere to happen. **The sentence after it is consequence.** It only makes sense because the moment already landed.

The backpack

This is what Dicks calls handing the listener your fear before you tell them what happened. You say what you thought was about to go wrong, and from that point on they're carrying it with you.

You already did the work for this back in step 2. Asking what would have happened if you'd done nothing is what turns up the fear. The backpack is just saying it out loud instead of leaving it implied. Most of us report the stakes as facts, which is accurate and flat. This is the difference between an interviewer knowing the stakes and feeling them.

One condition. It has to be true. If you weren't actually worried, don't manufacture it, because the whole point of this sheet is that you already lived something worth telling.

WHERE IT GOES **The last thing you say before you start describing what you did.** In practice that's the end of your Task, right on the seam between T and A. If the fear actually hit you earlier than that, put it earlier.

> WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE
>
> "So I had six weeks to replace a system the whole shop ran on, with no extra people and no overtime. My senior tech, nineteen years in, was telling anybody who'd listen that a spreadsheet would never survive an inspection, and honestly I thought he might be right. I went and asked him what specifically he thought would break."
>
> **The sentence before it is the end of the Task. The sentence after it is the start of the Action.** The backpack sits on the seam between them and costs you about four seconds.

Start at the opposite

Begin the story where you were the opposite of how it ends. If it ends with you competent, start with you not knowing. If it ends with the team running it without you, start with them refusing to touch it.

This is the fastest way to make ninety seconds feel like it went somewhere. A result lands harder when the listener can see how far you had to come to get there, and they can only see that if you show them where you started.

It's also the fix for the flattest kind of answer, the one that opens and closes at the same altitude. If your first sentence and your last sentence could trade places without anybody noticing, you haven't told a story yet.

If you've been wanting an opening line that actually grabs somebody, this is it. It works in an interview where a theatrical opener wouldn't, because all the weight is in the fact rather than the delivery. You're not performing anything. You're just refusing to start in the middle.

WHERE IT GOES **Your first sentence.** It replaces whatever you were going to open the Situation with, and it doesn't change the ending.

> WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE
>
> "The most experienced tech in my shop, nineteen years in, told me flatly that my tracking system wouldn't survive an inspection. Six weeks out from a change-of-command inspection, our database had locked read-only, and that spreadsheet was what I'd built to replace it."
>
> **There is no sentence above this one**, because it's the first thing out of your mouth. What it replaced was "our tracking database went read-only six weeks before a change-of-command inspection," which is where most people would start. **The sentence after it** does that old opening's job anyway, and now there's a distance between the two.

None of this changes what you built. You still work backward from the result, you still spend the ninety seconds where the angle tells you to, and you still sound like somebody who did a job rather than somebody performing one.
